

A SENSE OF COMFORT

Let's notice what feels okay right now

Level 1-3
5-20 minutes

Wellness Domains:

Environmental / Emotional

Topic: Personal Comfort & Grounding

Goal:

Participate in at least one tactile comparison that supports comfort or calm, as observed through verbal or nonverbal response.

Background:

Sensory comforts can be a great resource for anxiety or disquiet.

There is:

- No requirement to explain choices
- No expectation to finish
- No correct outcome

Success may include: selecting an item, holding an item, relaxing posture, or choosing to stop

Materials (Included/Subs):

1. Tactile comparison items (6-10 total)
 - Soft fibers
 - silk scarf, cotton cloth, fleece, faux fur, pompoms
 - Textured surfaces
 - burlap, tinsel, wood, bubble wrap
 - Firm objects
 - smooth stone, coin, shell
 - Flexible/resistant items
 - stress ball, thick ribbon, rubber band
 - Temperature
 - metal/wood, stone/fabric, ice pack
 - Weight/Density contrast
 - lightweight fabric/bean bag pouch, hollow object vs solid
2. Comfort set container
 - fabric pouch, bowl, envelope, plastic bag, designated table space
3. Optional: sorting surface
 - placemat, tray

Structure / Activity:

Invite your activity partner to compare items. Choose which feels better right now. Let them build a small comfort set from their selection.

Steps:

- Prepare the activity with items. It may be worthwhile to have some backup items.
- Present two tactile items
 - Items should be clearly different in texture
 - Only two items visible at a time
- Invite a choice
 - Participant indicates preference (pointing, touching, nodding, holding)
 - Mirror the choice
- Set aside the chosen item
 - Place in a designated "comfort area" (pouch, bowl, corner of table)
- Repeat with new pairs
 - The activity can end after one choice or continue until a set is formed.
 - Continue only while engagement is present
 - Repetition of materials is allowed.
- Pause or end
 - The comfort set may be used for quiet holding or simply acknowledged

Adaptations & Safety Precautions:

- Avoid novelty objects that imply play or childhood
- Avoid items that require precise manipulation
- Avoid fragile or high-value objects that create anxiety
- Place items in the person's hand if the person is visually impaired
- If your activity partner communicates refusal to engage, honor their choice and invite them to "observation only" where you complete the activity and they observe.
- Begin with familiar household textures, notice similarities before differences.